The Mihai Eminescu Trust

www.mihaieminescutrust.org

NEWSLETTER 2009-2010

A Decade of Achievement was the title under which The Mihai Eminescu Trust celebrated in 2009 ten years of work for the conservation and regeneration of the Saxon villages of Transylvania. The anniversary was marked by a series of exhibitions, talks and events in Romania and abroad, as well as the publication of a 32-page colour booklet in English, Romanian and German entitled "Transylvania Lost and Found". From Viscri, Sighisoara, Medias and Pitesti to Bucharest, Cluj-Napoca, Munich and Dublin, the Trust's pioneering Whole Village Project received the appreciation of thousands of national and international conservation experts, heritage and local authorities, universities, NGOs and local inhabitants. On 9th October the celebrated Romanian television news anchor, Andreea Esca, paid a visit to Viscri with Caroline Fernolend, afterwards moving on to the Apafi Manor in Malancrav with Andrea Rost. Her visit was screened on prime time television. With the help of a few generous and committed donors – especially the Packard Humanities Institute and Horizon Foundation – the first ten years of the Trust's activity have brought many tangible benefits to the 29 villages and towns where we have worked. Among these are: 130 local people trained in traditional building skills; 35 villagers trained in how to receive tourists; two traditional brick and tile kilns built, offering 15 jobs; 20 villagers helped to establish their own guesthouses; more than 300 houses, 50 barns and 22 churches rescued; and 14 schools and more than one thousand children involved in ecological education and reforestation.



Medias Synagogue



Maggie Cole at the Sighisoara Clavichord



Alma Vii village

THE WHOLE VILLAGE PROJECT

Viscri area: Over 114 historic facades were repaired in Crit and Mesendorf after the removal of electricity meters, under an agreement between the MET and the national electricity company. The unforeseen installation of these meters had caused considerable structural and aesthetic damage and their removal to inner courtyards followed an international petition organized by the MET. Two more barns and three houses were restored in **Crit**, while three houses, a roof and a gate were repaired in **Mesendorf**. In **Drauseni** we consolidated the walls, roof and front of a 17th century house and repaired two other exteriors. In **Viscri** 30 projects were completed. An oak bridge was built with the help of Colin Richards and his team of Shropshire craftsmen, improving access to the kiln and providing builders with a sand washing system and a free supply of sand. It will also reduce water damage to the wooden barns on the south side of the main street. Other projects included three barn restorations, two repairs of arched gates, four facades, two structural consolidations, a drainage system for the MET office and more than 50m of church wall repairs. Jan Hülsemann held a barn restoration seminar for the village carpenters. Throughout the village, 3200 meters of main sewage pipes have now been laid, thanks to support from HRH the Prince of Wales.

Malancrav area: In **Floresti** 15 projects were completed, including consolidations, house fronts, roofs and fences. In **Malancrav** 25 projects were completed. We restored the exterior of the local school and repaired and improved its interior, creating better conditions for the children.. Twelve facades and barn were repaired. The manor house has a new fountain. Jan Hülsemann held a seminar for village carpenters on repair of wooden windows, and another on barn construction. We thank Alina and Christian Scholtes for their time given to seminars for guesthouse ladies. We re-instated the traditional stone pavement and steps up to the Lutheran church and re-tiled the large roof on the priest's house.

We built a wooden bridge for the Orthodox church, to improve access. Two ecological toilets were installed in guesthouses and the Malancrav kiln had its first firing in October.

Alma Vii/Mosna area: The beautiful but vulnerable village of **Alma Vii** has attracted support from the Packard Humanities Institute and the Planet and Horizon Foundations, enabling us to obtain co-funding from EEA grants. This project is being undertaken in partnership with the Mosna Town Hall, the Sibiu County Heritage Department and the Norwegian Institute for Cultural Heritage Research. In the magnificent old school building, where we plan to open a heritage information and training centre, we have nearly finished a complex restoration project.

We are also restoring the old village shop and the public area by the fortified church We have repaired another four bridges, three facades and the village medical centre and re-paved 1300 sqm of cobbled pavement. The blacksmith and carpenter workshop has been repaired and is ready to receive a craftsman. Three local ladies attended an official tourism course, with the aim of developing their own guesthouses. UK expert Anthony Goode generously donated a week of his time to deliver a course in lime mortar and plaster to 9 craftsmen. In **Mosna**, the MET also completed the restoration of a historic building which will accommodate a village administration office and a tourist information centre for the Sibiu Eco-museum. In **Richis** we helped with the repair of the Lutheran church and supplied thousands of tiles.

OTHER VILLAGES

We have started work in **Archita** and established a lime pit and a storage house and begun a restoration project in the central square. With the help of MET co-financing, the Hosman Association completed the mill and bakery project and restored the old smithy. The team also repaired the facade of house no 214 in **Hosman** and the roof of the school in **Sacadate**. Stefan Vaida continued the restoration of house no 92 in **Altana**. In **Bikfalva** the village team (assisted by experts from Cluj University) cleaned and restored the gate at Zsigmond manor, revealing painted decorations and the date 1800. Extensive decorative paintings were also discovered on the walls of the Kóreh-Dénes manor. The completion of work on the church precincts in **Axente Sever** was celebrated in May 2009. Our architect has prepared drawings for a house restoration in **Copsa Mare**.

RURAL ENTREPRENEURS

In 2009 the MET obtained a generous grant from Citi-Foundation to help small rural entrepreneurs initiate and develop sustainable businesses. Over two years this will enable us to train local people, support village workshops and conservation teams, and market and promote traditional local produce.

BREITE

Now in our fourth year as custodians of the Breite Ancient Oak Tree Reserve, we have accomplished more than 70% of the targets set out in our management plan. With the help of an EEA grant, we carried out a number of conservation measures, including introduction of controlled grazing and protection of young trees, and have focused on community engagement, targeting especially young people through local schools. In October 2009 we organised the "Oak Tree for Every Pupil" campaign, during which more than 500 pupils from ten Sighisoara schools planted 600 oak saplings on the Breite plateau. We also launched the Day of the Breite Reserve and established a regular consultation panel for the management, conservation and enjoyment of the nature reserve. A new information point, funded by NatuRegio, includes scientific equipment and biology books. Five new panels, near the visitor centre, describe the key natural values of the plateau. In Stejareni, a village close to Breite, the Trust is restoring a small farmhouse, which will accommodate an organic animal farm with buffalo and goats, managed by a local farmer. As part of the Breite management plan, the animals will graze on the plateau during the summer.

WOOD PASTURES

Modelled on its Breite experience, the Trust has started to study, record and protect other wood pastures with veteran trees from an area of over 126,000 ha in south-eastern Transylvania. Typical of the rural landscape of the Saxon villages, these wood pastures with scattered trees have suffered from neglect and vandalism over the past fifty years, due to the gradual abandonment of traditional farming. Almost every Saxon village has a wood pasture nearby – the Trust's biologists have studied 36 such habitats and identified more than 150 trees with a circumference of over 4.7m. Five of these habitats are so valuable that we are proposing to designate them nature reserves. As part of this project, we are producing a guide for local farmers to access funding that could help them preserve the pastures and the ancient trees, as well as a good practice manual for their management; and we launched a contest to "Find the Oldest Tree". Almost 300 school children sent us their photos and recordings of ancient trees throughout the area – one of them as large as 9.1m. The top five contestants received camping and outdoors equipment as prizes.

RAILWAY

The Friends of the Sibiu Agnita Railway are working,

with the help of the MET, to repair a length of track, a train carriage and part of the Agnita station, in preparation for the celebration of the line's 100th birthday in September. They are also hoping to obtain a working narrow gauge steam engine, so that a train can travel once again on the line. The carriage is one of the four found in Sibiu that were saved from scrapping with a donation from the Trust and are currently housed in a depot in Agnita.

FORTIFIED CHURCHES

MET architects completed the architectural, structural, historic and archaeological documentation for eight of the Saxon fortifications in the Evangelic Church's 18-church Kirchenburg Project. Conservation architect Jan Huelsemann trained and guided the architects to ensure the interventions are done according to the MET's principles of minimum intervention. All eight projects received planning permission.

PLANT FOR THE PLANET

The MET has been chosen as one of seven NGOs worldwide to implement reforestation projects in Romania, as part of the Plant for the Planet programme run by the French hotel company Accor. When guests who stay in Accor hotels re-use their towels, they help save money and energy: half of the savings are directed to the MET's Forest for Each School project in Transylvania. In April 2009 the MET and local partners completed the first 10-hectare tree plantation, in the village of Micasasa near Medias. More than 200 children from the village school and from neighbouring high schools planted 10,000 young saplings - mainly oak trees from the MET's nursery in Sighisoara, but also some wild cherry, ash, maple, lime and walnut. Another 10-hectare plantation is being created this spring, with the help of the local school and the mayor, in Seica Mica.

SYNAGOGUE

As part of its project to restore the Jewish synagogue in Medias and turn it into a cultural centre, the MET organized an open house weekend and a photographic exhibition of southern Transylvanian synagogues. Julie Dawson spoke of Jewish culture in Transylvania, followed by a historical presentation by the director of the Medias Town Museum, and an insight into the restoration project itself from MET architects Irina Baldescu and Letitia Cosnean. So far, we have carried out emergency repairs on the roof and on the interior and exterior walls, and have restored part of the old Rabbi's house as an office and for the safekeeping of the archive. Later in the year, the Romanian ambassador gave a lunch, attended by Lord Rothschild, Lord Kalms and Dame Vivian Duffield, to celebrate the London opening of the exhibition, hosted by The Romanian Cultural Institute. In February this year the Spiro Ark Centre in London and the trustees of the MET held an event highlighting Romania's rich Jewish cultural heritage.

NEW PARTNERSHIPS

In November the MET signed a long-term partnership with the rector of the Academy of Economic Studies in Bucharest, Professor Ion Gheorghe ROSCA, and Professors Calin Veghes, Oana Popescu and Diana Balan. This long term partnership with an academy containing 22,000 students aims to further the MET philosophy of rural revival. The focus will be on heritage restoration and the development of eco-tourism in the 25 villages where the MET's work is concentrated.

The MET also signed a contract with the history and philosophy department of the Cluj Babes-Bolyai University to run a postgraduate course of lectures in Viscri entitled "How to make use of Heritage".

Finally, the MET signed a partnership with the Romanian Academy in Cluj-Napoca focusing on social and academic aspects of combining tradition with contemporary creativity.

AWARDS

At the ninth International Green Apple Awards for the Built Environment and Architectural Heritage the Trust won a Gold Award for Viscri, as World Heritage Village, and a Silver Award for the Apafi Manor House, Malancrav.

At a ceremony in Sibiu, the MET was awarded the Ministry of Culture's Diploma of Excellence for its contribution to the conservation and promotion of cultural heritage in Sibiu county.

SPREADING THE MESSAGE

Jeremy Amos, Trustee of the Horizon Foundation, gave a talk on the Trust's Whole Village Project in Saxon Transylvania to post-graduates attending the Conservation Course at London's Architectural Association.

Jessica Douglas-Home spoke at the MET 10-year celebration in Bucharest at the Academy of Economic Studies. She gave a talk on Culture and Eastern Europe to Weidenfeld scholars at Hartwell Manor, Oxford, followed by a seminar on the Saxon Villages in Transylvania with Professor John Adamson. She also gave a talk on Romania's Jewish Heritage at the Ark Foundation, London.

Caroline Fernolend opened in Viscri the first exhibition to celebrate 10 years of Trust work. She travelled with the exhibition during the year to Medias, Sibiu, Bucharest, Brasov, Cluj, Biertan and Sighisoara. In Bucharest she spoke at the Academy of Economic Studies (together with Christian Tabara from National

TV) and at the Sociology Faculty; in Sinaia at the "Urban Concept" conference; and in Pitesti on architecture. She gave 16 further presentations of the Trust's work in Romanian cities, towns and villages as well as in Germany and Belgium. She also gave interviews to Romania's National and German Section National TV, to Suddeutsche Zeitung-Germany, Pro TV, NDR TV Germany, Deutsche Welle, Forbes Magazine, Readers Digest Romania, the Munich Siebenbürgische Zeitung and to the Foreign Ministry in Bucharest to mark 20 years after the fall of communism.

Luminita Holban gave a talk at a conference in Nisovo, Bulgaria, about the Trust's Whole Village Project. In Mosna, with local Mayor Eugen Roba and the vice-president of the Sibiu County Council, she inaugurated the building which now houses an office for the Local Action Group and a tourist information centre for the Sibiu Eco-museum. At the International Conference of National Trusts, Dublin, she presented the Trust's work as a model for sustainable rural development through heritage. Later she accompanied the Chairman of the National Trust to visit MET projects. In London, at the Ark Foundation, she spoke about the restoration of the Medias synagogue.

Andrea Rost, MET tourism manager, received many distinguished visitors at the Apafi Manor during the year including the Chairman of the National Trust, Simon Jenkins, and the founder of Everyman Publishing House, David Campbell. The celebrated Romanian television star Andreea Esca also visited, as well as Herzogin Diane von Würtemberg, Princess von Frankreich, and the former and present Romanian Ambassadors of Mexico.

Jan Hülsemann gave a presentation on the MET's preservation projects at an international conference on the threat to historic urban cultural landscapes in Osnabrück, Germany. He also gave MET presentations in Malancrav to Bavarian education specialists and in Sighisoara to the German Forum on traditional handcrafts in historic towns. He spoke on the Trust's work in Axente Sever in Viscri, in Medias and at an international conference on "The restoration of monuments from the point of view of environmental impacts".

Letitia Cosnean and Julie Dawson outlined the Trust's restoration of the Medias Synagogue at the Romanian Cultural Institute in London.

Maggie Cole, the illustrious international harpsichordist, played at the Sibiu Festival in a Words and Music concert of *Violet*. She travelled on to Sighisoara where she performed on the Transylvanian Samuel Maetz clavichord in front of a small invited audience in the citadel's Museum.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

Our work owes more than we can ever say to the understanding and generosity of our principal donor, the Packard Humanities Institute. We are also much indebted to the Horizon Foundation for its financial support and wise advice.

We thank our patron HRH The Prince of Wales for his grant to Archita and for finding the time among his crowded duties to help us in numerous human ways;. We are grateful to the Planet Foundation for its generous support for Alma Vii. We also owe our gratitude to the EEA and supporting grants from Norway, Iceland and Lichtenstein for projects in Alma Vii, Viscri, Malancrav and Breite; and to Deutsche Bundesstiftung Umwelt and Alfred Toepfer Stiftung; to Rothschild Foundation Europe; to Lord Leach of Fairford; to CitiFoundation; to Accor; and to the Foundation for Partnership.

We are grateful to the Horizon Foundation, Bill Parker and David Jones for their support in setting up the Stejareni farm, as well as to Colin Richards and his Shropshire craftsmen, who helped us build its large, traditional stable. Here and in all villages where we operate, our work continues to be transformed by the commitment of Colin Richards and his exceptional Shropshire team.

OTHER INFORMATION

The achievements of the Trust are only made possible by your donations. Please send any gift possible to our office: The Mihai Eminescu Trust, 38 Hazel Road, London NW10 5PP, where books, brochures and information about all our activities are available.